Partisan Effects of Religious Peer Groups

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Job Talk
September 28, 2026

Outline

1. Motivation
2. Background on Setting
3. Empirical Strategy
4. Main Results
5. Validation and Robustness
6. Mechanisms

Partisan peer effects are important

- Partisan identity shapes economic behavior
  - **macro expectations** (Mian, Sufi & Khoshkhou, 2023), **hiring** (Colonnelli, Neto & Teso, 2025), **fertility** (Dahl, Lu & Mullins, 2022), **tax compliance** (Cullen, Turner & Washington, 2021)
- Economics largely treats political identity as a primitive. Where does it come from?
  - **This talk:** is it transmitted through peer networks?
- The answer determines the stakes of an important trend: Americans are increasingly segregated by partisanship in where they live, work, worship, and consume (Brown & Enos, 2021)
  - Peer transmission $\Rightarrow$ segregation amplifies polarization via a social multiplier (Glaeser, Sacerdote & Scheinkman, 2003)
  - No transmission $\Rightarrow$ sorting is merely a symptom of polarization

But challenging to identify

Research Question

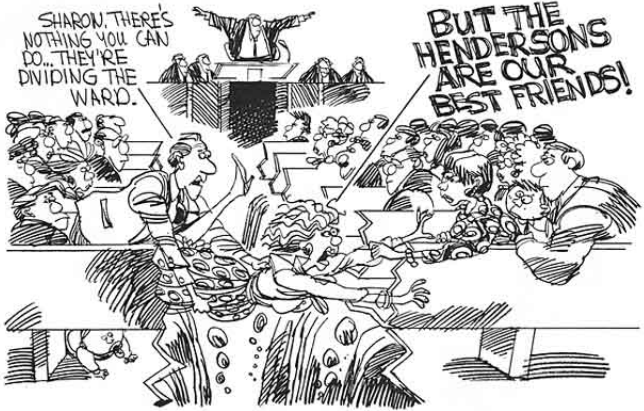
How does the partisan composition of peers affect political affiliation?

Hard to answer: peer correlations conflate *selection*, *shared context*, and *peer influence* (Manski, 1993)

The ideal experiment:

- Randomly assign adults to peer groups with different partisan mixes
- Hold everything else fixed: home, neighborhood, job, local institutions
- Peer group is consequential: sustained interaction over years
- Observe peer groups and political behavior over a long horizon

Natural experiment: LDS congregations



Cartoon by Calvin Grondahl

LDS congregational assignment approximate the ideal experiment

Geographic reassignment of LDS* church members to congregations ("wards") approximates the ideal experiment

- **Random assignment:** members are quasi-exogenously assigned to new wards based on home address
- **Everything else fixed:** reassignment changes nothing but the congregation—same home, neighborhood, job
- **Consequential peer group:** weekly attendance, lay ministry, close friendships (closer than work friends)
- **Long horizon:** ward boundaries are linkable to address-level voter files giving party affiliation from 2012 to 2020

*The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints

Preview of Paper

- Compare partisan changes between neighbors living on opposite sides of newly drawn boundary lines
  - Spatial difference-in-discontinuity, partisan share of new ward as treatment dose
  - Argue that boundary placement as-good-as-random
- Find that voters conform to the partisanship of their peers
  - Assignment to more Republican side increases Republican affiliation by 1 p.p.
- Effects not driven by:
  - Correlated peer characteristics
  - Religious leader effects
- Stronger effects between same-demographic peers
- **Conclusion:** effects represent direct peer-to-peer transmission of partisanship

Contributions

1. **Why places are politically segregated:** segregation across neighborhoods (Brown and Enos 2021; Brown et al. 2025), workplaces (Chinoy and Koenen 2024), place effects (Cantoni and Pons 2022)
   - *This paper:* clean peer variation among adults of all ages $\Rightarrow$ sorting feeds polarization

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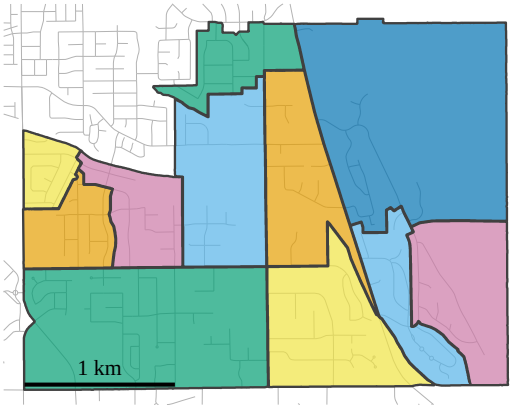
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4. **Settings with exogenous assignment to peers:** roommates (Sacerdote 2001), schools (Angrist and Lang 2004), military squadrons (Carrell, Sacerdote, and West 2013), coworkers (Mas and Moretti 2009)
   - *This paper:* novel design for studying how social influence transmits within church congregations

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Wards are geographically defined

- A **ward** is a geographically defined congregation: members attend the ward that contains their home
- Wards are small: median area 0.5 km^2, $\approx$150 weekly attendees
- 5-11 contiguous wards (median 8) form a **stake**



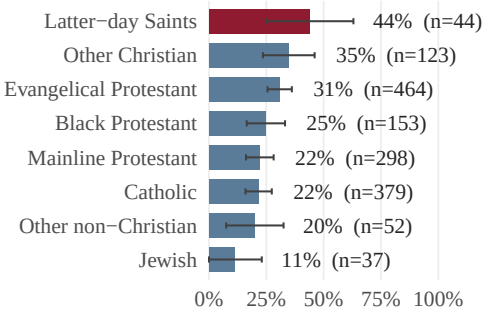
Example stake with 11 wards (2014)
Pleasant Grove, UT

Wards are a consequential peer group

- More friends in congregation than other religious traditions
- Highest weekly attendance (88%)
- High church volunteering (≈8 hours/week)
- Interaction throughout the week
  - Lay-ministry assignments, service projects, sports leagues, youth activities
- Ward ties stronger than work ties

Close friends in the same congregation

Share of attenders reporting six or more close friends in their congregation, by tradition

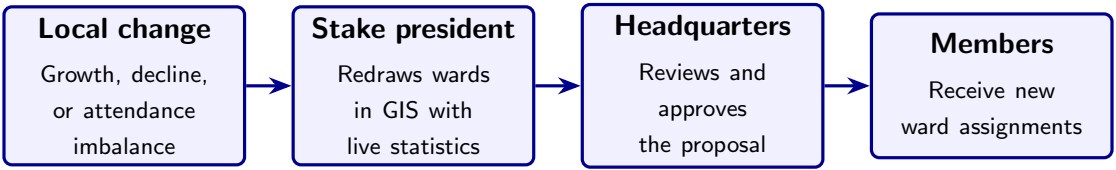


Faith Matters Survey 2011 (n = 1,550 attenders, weighted by WGTTOT11). 95% CIs.

▸ Ward vs. work friends ▸ Weekly attendance ▸ Volunteering

How ward boundaries are redrawn

- Boundary changes are initiated and drawn by the **stake president**, the lay leader of a stake
- We surveyed and interviewed 22 former Utah stake presidents who served during study window to understand the process



Survey questions

Why boundaries are redrawn

Wards are operated by a lay ministry, so ward size matters

> *"The original two wards were very large and because of that there were many members that were not having opportunities to serve."*
>
> — former stake president
> on why he created a new ward

> *"The ward simply did not have a sufficient number of active members to staff up the ward. Everyone who was active had two and three jobs. The ward was incapable of delivering a functioning youth program."*
>
> — former stake president
> on why he closed an old ward

In our data, wards are **created** where population and new construction grow, and **closed** where population stagnates

▸ Growth by change type ▸ New construction

Factors considered when drawing boundaries

Official church guidelines: $\geq$250 members, $\geq$20 leadership-eligible men.

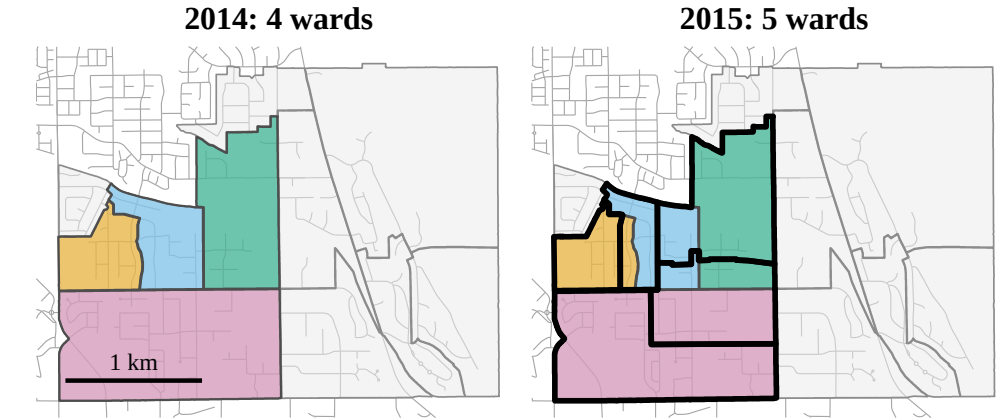
Additional informal considerations

- **Youth:** enough children and teens for children and youth programs
- **Mix:** combine richer and poorer areas to balance welfare needs and leadership
- **Neighborhoods, not individuals:** partisanship and income unobserved; lines typically drawn around neighborhoods, not individual households
- **GIS app:** shows these counts for every draft map

> *"The socioeconomic conditions were more just at the neighborhood level, not individual. . . . we didn't want a ward of all government-subsidized apartment buildings (less affluent, more transient) . . . We wanted a mix."*
> — former stake president

> *"We made a goal to not have immediate neighbors, or neighbors on the same street, or homes facing each other in different units."*
> — former stake president

Example boundary change

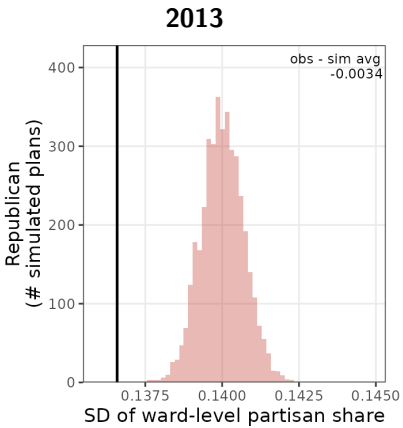


Same stake as before, 2014 → 2015: four wards reorganized into five. Colors mark the pre-change wards; bold lines are the new boundaries, so each new ward combines members of several old wards.

Actual ward dispersion vs. counterfactual simulations

Test whether wards segregated voters relative to underlying geography

- Resimulate wards within each stake
- Calculate partisan dispersion across simulated plans
- Compare to dispersion across actual wards
- Findings consistent with balancing motive



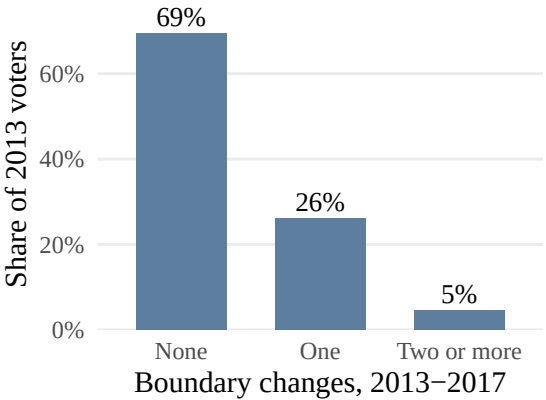
Compliance is high

- Respondents recall only one or two members in their entire tenure attending outside their assigned ward; one estimated non-compliance at under 1%
- Membership records must sit in the assigned ward to:
  - hold a lay-ministry position
  - baptize children
  - seek welfare assistance from the bishop

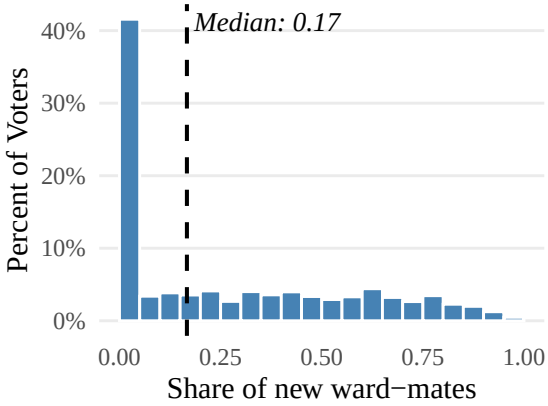
  Exceptions require approval from Church headquarters
- A strong cultural norm:

> *"Wards are chosen for us based on a reasonable geographic alignment, and we learn to live with, serve, and love people who might well be different in background, preferences, and opinions."*
>
> — Church Newsroom (2023)

How large and frequent are the changes?



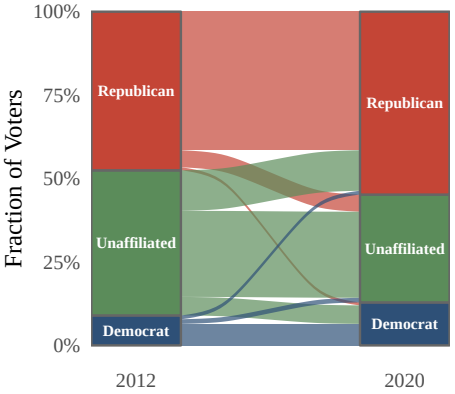
Boundary changes experienced by 2013 voters



Share of new ward-mates among affected voters (median 16.7%)

Background on Utah politics

- **2012:** 45% Republican, 46% Unaffiliated, 9% Democrat
- **Substantial switching, 2012–2020:** 27.9% of Unaffiliated became Republican; 12.7% of Republicans left the party
- **Closed Republican primary:** usually decisive ⇒ strategic reason to register Republican



Party registration flows, 2012 → 2020

▸ Independents' vote ▸ Ward partisanship map

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Data

TargetSmart voter files

Annual, 2012–2021

Variables: party, turnout, age, sex, race, name, address

Note: We do not observe religion, so we restrict to Utah, where 61–69% of residents are LDS.

▸ LDS share by county ▸ Switching by year ▸ Summary statistics ▸ Sample comparison ▸ Linked voters ▸ Linked properties

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TargetSmart voter files

Annual, 2012–2021

Variables: party, turnout, age, sex, race, name, address

Restrict to Utah in 2012 + observed in 2020/21

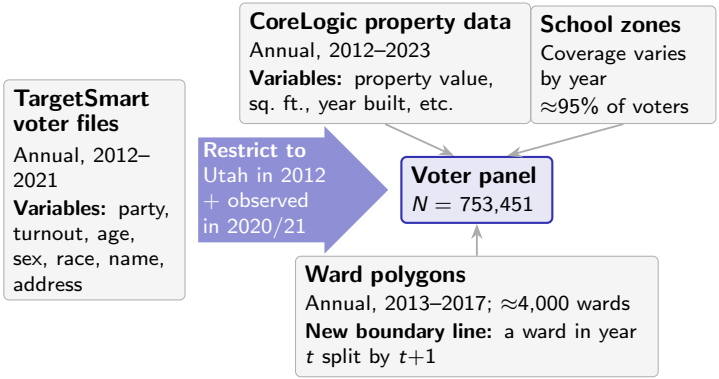
Voter panel

$N = 753{,}451$

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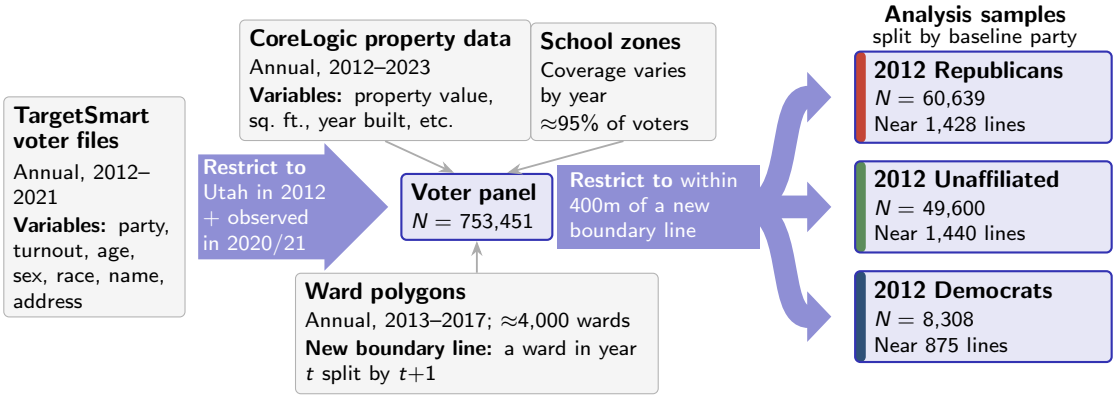
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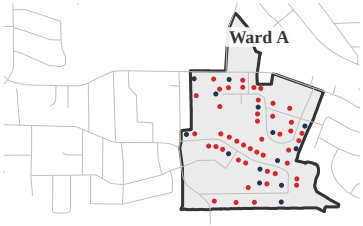
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Research Design: Spatial DiD

Ward = LDS Congregation

(a) Baseline (2012)



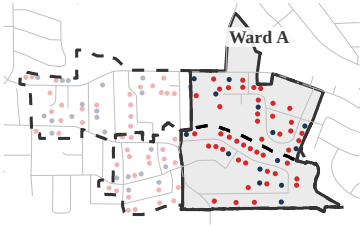
Ward A: 69% Republican

Non−Republican Republican

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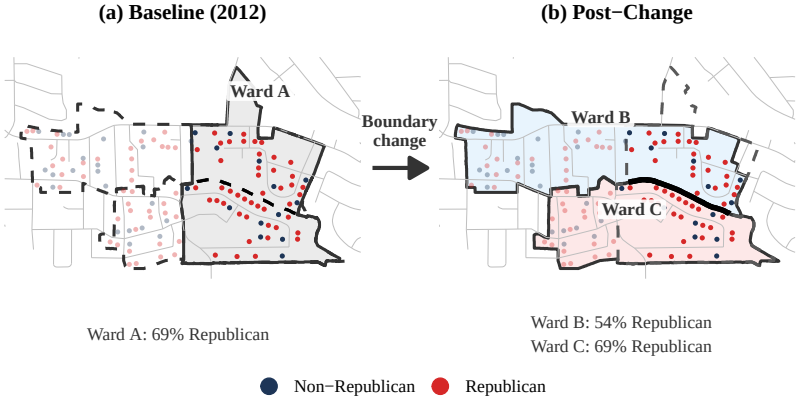


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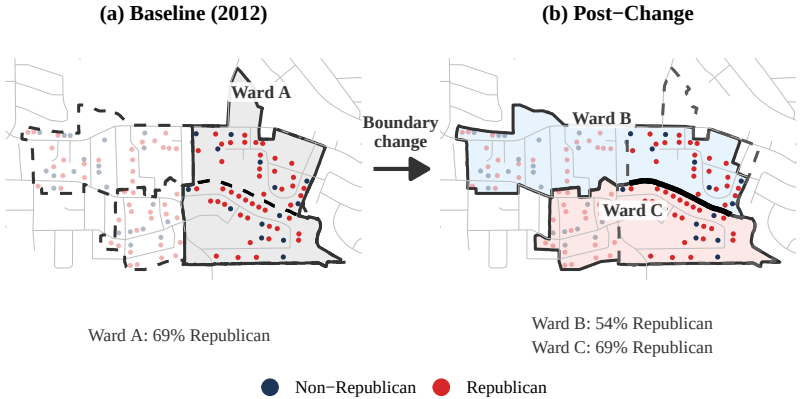
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Look at wards that split between 2013 and 2017

Compare partisan changes between neighbors living near new boundary line on opposite sides.

Key assumption: New boundary lines are locally exogenous to trends in political outcomes.

Estimating equation

$$\Delta Y_{ib} \;=\; \beta\left(D_{ib} \times |p_b - q_b|\right) \;+\; \delta\, D_{ib} \;+\; \mu_b \;+\; f(r_{ib}) \;+\; \mathbf{X}_i'\gamma \;+\; \varepsilon_{ib}$$

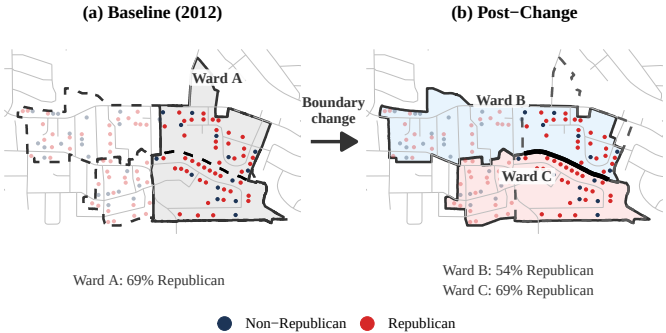
- $i,\ b$ voter; newly drawn boundary
- D_{ib} 1 on the higher-share side
- β effect of a 0-to-1 change in peer share
- μ_b boundary fixed effect
- $\mathbf{X}_i$ baseline controls (robustness only)
- ΔY_{ib} registration change, 2012–2020
- $p_b,\ q_b$ baseline peer shares in the two new wards
- δ high-side intercept at zero gap
- $f(r_{ib})$ side-specific quadratic in distance

Standard errors clustered two-way by boundary side and voter

All regressions are split by baseline party affiliation

Defining treatment

$$\Delta Y_{ib} = \beta \left(D_{ib} \times |p_b - q_b| \right) + \delta D_{ib} + \mu_b + f(r_{ib}) + \mathbf{X}_i'\gamma + \varepsilon_{ib}$$



$D_{ib} = 1$ for i on high-share side of new line b, and 0 for i on low-share side

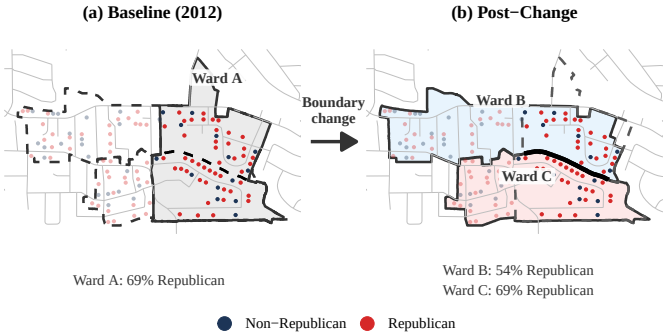
Example:

- $D_{ib} = 1$ for $i \in \text{Ward} C \cap A$
- $D_{ib} = 0$ for $i \in \text{Ward} B \cap A$

Both sides are treated, difference is intensity

Defining treatment

$$\Delta Y_{ib} = \beta \left(D_{ib} \times |p_b - q_b| \right) + \delta D_{ib} + \mu_b + f(r_{ib}) + \mathbf{X}_i' \gamma + \varepsilon_{ib}$$

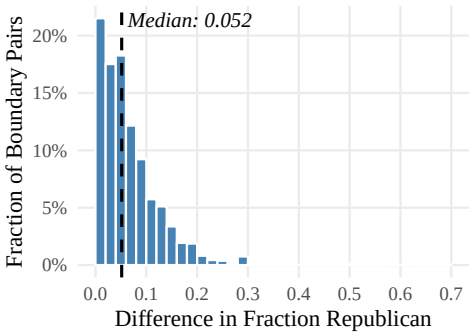


p_b, q_b: leave-one-out partisan shares of the two new wards

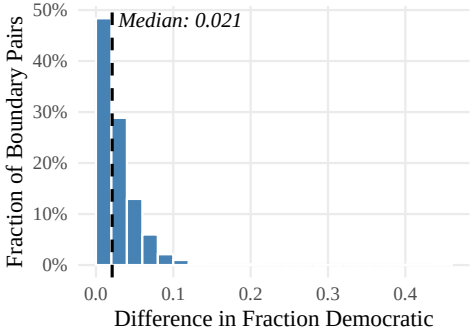
- party affiliation and address measured at baseline (2012)
- measured over full ward rosters

Example:
$|p_b - q_b| = |0.69 - 0.54| = 0.15$

Distribution of treatment intensity



(a) Republican-share treatment



(b) Democratic-share treatment

One observation per newly drawn boundary: $|p_b - q_b|$, the gap in baseline (2012) partisan share between the two new wards. Dashed line: median.

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Main results — 2012 Republicans

	Democratic-share treatment			Republican-share treatment			Both treatments		
	ΔRep	ΔUnaff	ΔDem	ΔRep	ΔUnaff	ΔDem	ΔRep	ΔUnaff	ΔDem
$D_{ib}^{\text{Dem}} \times I_b^{\text{Dem}}$	−0.322**								
	(0.133)								
$D_{ib}^{\text{Rep}} \times I_b^{\text{Rep}}$									
Dep. Var. Mean	-0.139								
# Voters	60,639								
# Boundaries	1,428								

Coefficients per 0-to-1 change in peer share. SEs two-way clustered by boundary side and voter.

Main results — 2012 Republicans

	Democratic-share treatment			Republican-share treatment			Both treatments		
	ΔRep	ΔUnaff	ΔDem	ΔRep	ΔUnaff	ΔDem	ΔRep	ΔUnaff	ΔDem
$D_{ib}^{\text{Dem}} \times I_b^{\text{Dem}}$	−0.322**	0.161	0.161***						
	(0.133)	(0.114)	(0.048)						
$D_{ib}^{\text{Rep}} \times I_b^{\text{Rep}}$									
Dep. Var. Mean	-0.139	0.121	0.018						
# Voters	60,639	60,639	60,639						
# Boundaries	1,428	1,428	1,428						

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Main results — 2012 Republicans

	Democratic-share treatment			Republican-share treatment			Both treatments		
	ΔRep	ΔUnaff	ΔDem	ΔRep	ΔUnaff	ΔDem	ΔRep	ΔUnaff	ΔDem
$D_{ib}^{\text{Dem}} \times I_b^{\text{Dem}}$	−0.322**	0.161	0.161***						
	(0.133)	(0.114)	(0.048)						
$D_{ib}^{\text{Rep}} \times I_b^{\text{Rep}}$				0.079	−0.033	−0.047**			
				(0.057)	(0.053)	(0.020)			
Dep. Var. Mean	-0.139	0.121	0.018	-0.139	0.121	0.018			
# Voters	60,639	60,639	60,639	60,639	60,639	60,639			
# Boundaries	1,428	1,428	1,428	1,428	1,428	1,428			

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Main results — 2012 Republicans

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	ΔRep	ΔUnaff	ΔDem	ΔRep	ΔUnaff	ΔDem	ΔRep	ΔUnaff	ΔDem
$D_{ib}^{\text{Dem}} \times I_b^{\text{Dem}}$	−0.322**	0.161	0.161***				−0.291**	0.143	0.148***
	(0.133)	(0.114)	(0.048)				(0.139)	(0.119)	(0.050)
$D_{ib}^{\text{Rep}} \times I_b^{\text{Rep}}$				0.079	−0.033	−0.047**	0.044	−0.011	−0.034*
				(0.057)	(0.053)	(0.020)	(0.058)	(0.055)	(0.019)
Dep. Var. Mean	-0.139	0.121	0.018	-0.139	0.121	0.018	-0.139	0.121	0.018
# Voters	60,639	60,639	60,639	60,639	60,639	60,639	60,639	60,639	60,639
# Boundaries	1,428	1,428	1,428	1,428	1,428	1,428	1,428	1,428	1,428

Coefficients per 0-to-1 change in peer share. SEs two-way clustered by boundary side and voter.

Main results — 2012 Unaffiliated voters

	Democratic-share treatment			Republican-share treatment			Both treatments		
	ΔRep	ΔUnaff	ΔDem	ΔRep	ΔUnaff	ΔDem	ΔRep	ΔUnaff	ΔDem
$D_{ib}^{\text{Dem}} \times I_b^{\text{Dem}}$	−0.182	0.117	0.064						
	(0.176)	(0.179)	(0.117)						
$D_{ib}^{\text{Rep}} \times I_b^{\text{Rep}}$									
Dep. Var. Mean	0.295	-0.401	0.106						
# Voters	49,600	49,600	49,600						
# Boundaries	1,440	1,440	1,440						

Coefficients per 0-to-1 change in peer share. SEs two-way clustered by boundary side and voter.

Main results — 2012 Unaffiliated voters

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	ΔRep	ΔUnaff	ΔDem	ΔRep	ΔUnaff	ΔDem	ΔRep	ΔUnaff	ΔDem
$D_{ib}^{\text{Dem}} \times I_b^{\text{Dem}}$	−0.182	0.117	0.064						
	(0.176)	(0.179)	(0.117)						
$D_{ib}^{\text{Rep}} \times I_b^{\text{Rep}}$				0.228***	−0.120	−0.108**			
				(0.080)	(0.079)	(0.050)			
Dep. Var. Mean	0.295	-0.401	0.106	0.295	-0.401	0.106			
# Voters	49,600	49,600	49,600	49,600	49,600	49,600			
# Boundaries	1,440	1,440	1,440	1,440	1,440	1,440			

Coefficients per 0-to-1 change in peer share. SEs two-way clustered by boundary side and voter.

Main results — 2012 Unaffiliated voters

	Democratic-share treatment			Republican-share treatment			Both treatments		
	ΔRep	ΔUnaff	ΔDem	ΔRep	ΔUnaff	ΔDem	ΔRep	ΔUnaff	ΔDem
$D_{ib}^{\text{Dem}} \times I_b^{\text{Dem}}$	−0.182	0.117	0.064				−0.029	0.051	−0.023
	(0.176)	(0.179)	(0.117)				(0.185)	(0.195)	(0.123)
$D_{ib}^{\text{Rep}} \times I_b^{\text{Rep}}$				0.228***	−0.120	−0.108**	0.213**	−0.121	−0.092*
				(0.080)	(0.079)	(0.050)	(0.085)	(0.086)	(0.053)
Dep. Var. Mean	0.295	-0.401	0.106	0.295	-0.401	0.106	0.295	-0.401	0.106
# Voters	49,600	49,600	49,600	49,600	49,600	49,600	49,600	49,600	49,600
# Boundaries	1,440	1,440	1,440	1,440	1,440	1,440	1,440	1,440	1,440

Coefficients per 0-to-1 change in peer share. SEs two-way clustered by boundary side and voter.

Interpreting effect sizes

- β is the effect of a **0-to-1** change in ward peer share
- Under random friending, also effect of a **0-to-1** change in friend group share
  - Underestimate with homophily
- With small friend groups, small ward variation $\implies$ large changes for a few friend groups

Example: each member has one friend; Ward A is 45% Republican, Ward B is 50%

$\rightarrow$ Assignment to B vs. A gives 5 pp more members a Republican friend

$\rightarrow$ For those 5%, friend-group share jumps from 0 to 1

$\rightarrow$ Each becomes β more likely to be Republican

From coefficients to a typical boundary

- β is the effect of a **0-to-1** change in peer share
- Actual cross-boundary gaps much smaller
- **Rescaling:** multiply by the voter-weighted average gap

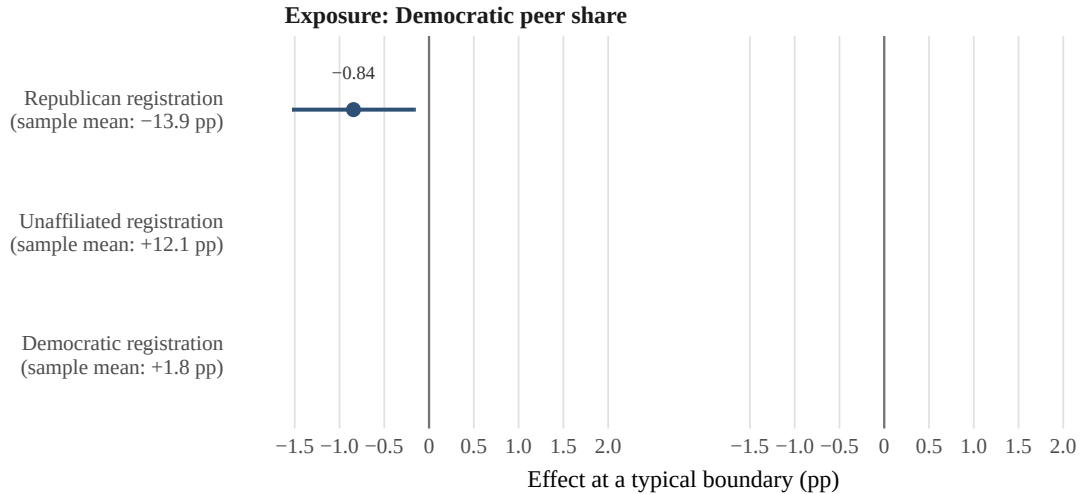
$$\tilde{\beta} = \hat{\beta} \times \frac{\sum_b N_b |p_b - q_b|}{\sum_b N_b} \qquad \text{(5.9 pp Republican, 2.6 pp Democratic)}$$

$\tilde{\beta}$: how much a boundary line matters in practice

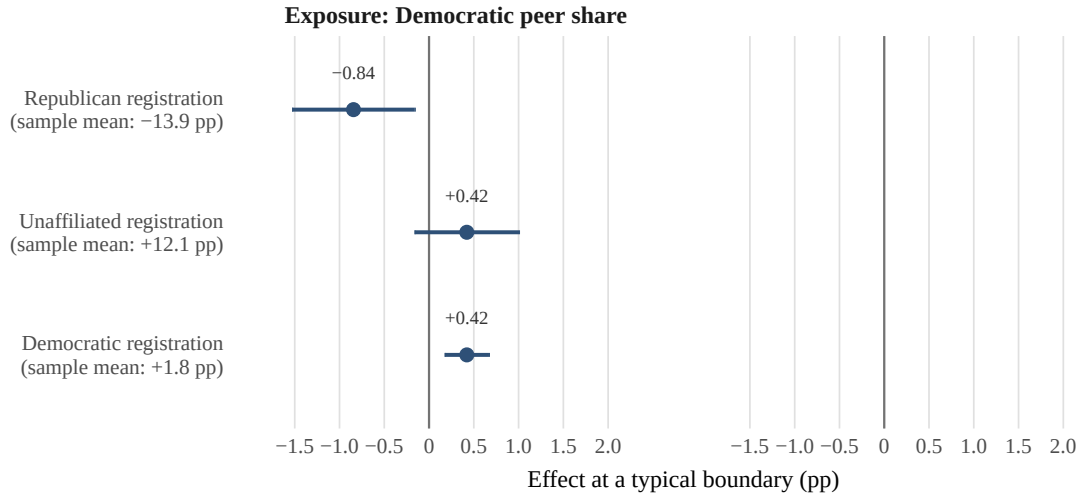
- The average effect of randomly assigning a voter to the high side of a line instead of the low side
- Equivalently, the share of voters whose 2020 registration changed because of which side of the line they landed on

▸ Distribution of gaps

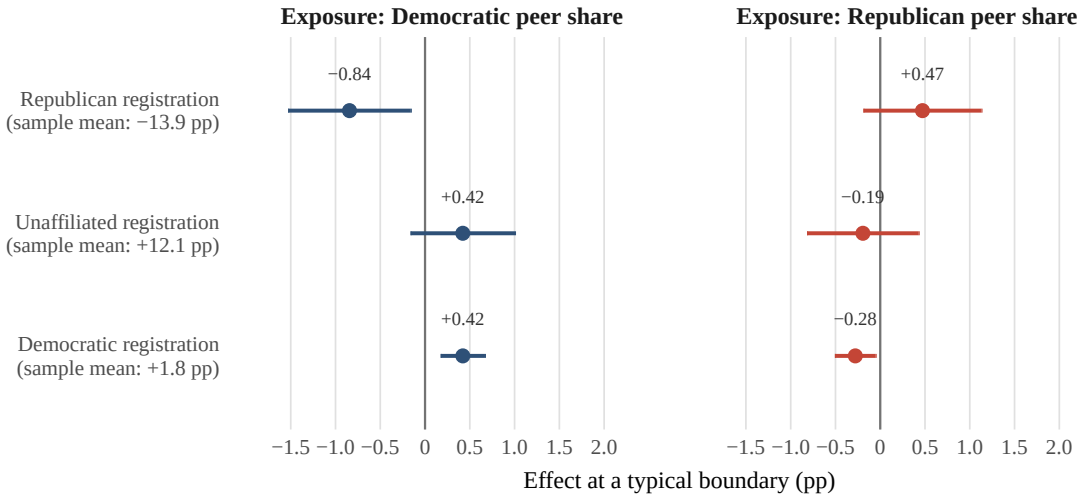
Effect of peer partisanship — 2012 Republicans



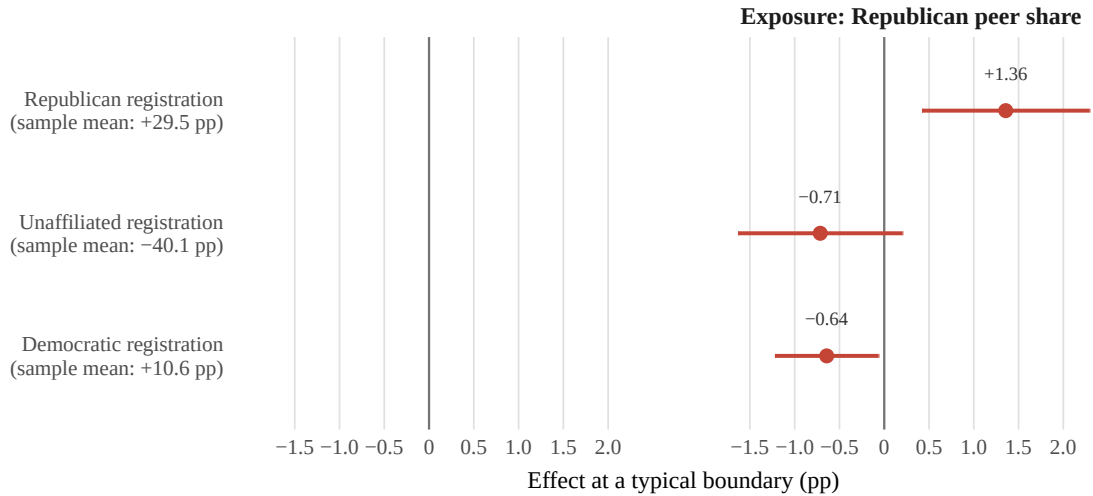
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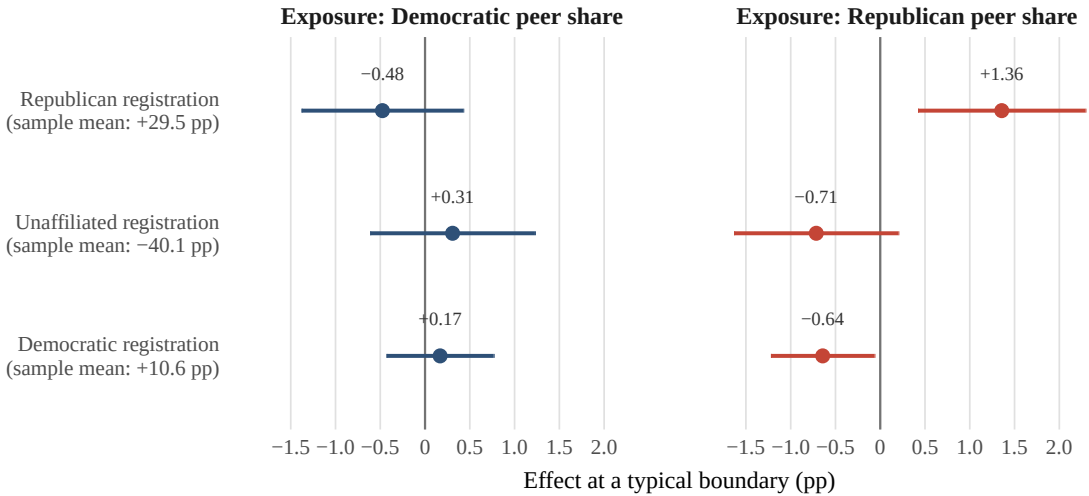
Effect of peer partisanship — 2012 Republicans



Effect of peer partisanship — 2012 Unaffiliated voters



Effect of peer partisanship — 2012 Unaffiliated voters



Adjusting for missing LDS status

We do not observe religion: every voter enters the sample and the peer share, but only LDS members should respond to ward assignment ⇒ estimates are attenuated

$$k_{p,X} = \frac{\mathbb{E}\left[\hat{\beta}_{p,X}\right]}{\beta_{\text{true}}} = \underbrace{p_{\text{LDS}}(p)}_{\text{share who respond}} \cdot \underbrace{\frac{Z^{\text{LDS}}_{X,A} - Z^{\text{LDS}}_{X,B}}{Z^{\text{obs}}_{X,A} - Z^{\text{obs}}_{X,B}}}_{\text{peer-mismeasurement ratio}}$$

- $k_{p,X}$: attenuation for baseline party p, exposure X (Rep. or Dem. peer share); A, B: new wards
- **Share who respond:** P(LDS | party p) from the Utah Colleges Exit Poll: 0.85 R, 0.50 U, 0.25 D
- **Peer ratio:** LDS-only peer gap (Z^{LDS}) relative to the observed all-voter gap (Z^{obs})

Adjustment multipliers ($1/k$)

	Baseline party		
Exposure	Republican	Unaffiliated	Democrat
Republican peer share	1.28	2.17	4.34
Democratic peer share	2.55	4.34	8.68

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Same design, using boundaries drawn 2023–2026, after the 2012–2020 outcome window

- Tests whether 2012–2020 partisan trends predict where 2023–2026 new boundaries are drawn

Placebo: future boundaries — 2012 Republicans

	Democratic-share treatment			Republican-share treatment			Both treatments		
	ΔRep	ΔUnaff	ΔDem	ΔRep	ΔUnaff	ΔDem	ΔRep	ΔUnaff	ΔDem
$D_{ib}^{\text{Dem}} \times I_b^{\text{Dem}}$	−0.122	0.003	0.119						
	(0.176)	(0.148)	(0.074)						
$D_{ib}^{\text{Rep}} \times I_b^{\text{Rep}}$									
Dep. Var. Mean	-0.146	0.124	0.022						
# Voters	44,324	44,324	44,324						
# Boundaries	1,029	1,029	1,029						

▸ Placebo sample

Placebo: future boundaries — 2012 Republicans

	Democratic-share treatment			Republican-share treatment			Both treatments		
	ΔRep	ΔUnaff	ΔDem	ΔRep	ΔUnaff	ΔDem	ΔRep	ΔUnaff	ΔDem
$D_{ib}^{\text{Dem}} \times I_b^{\text{Dem}}$	−0.122	0.003	0.119						
	(0.176)	(0.148)	(0.074)						
$D_{ib}^{\text{Rep}} \times I_b^{\text{Rep}}$				−0.112	0.131*	−0.019			
				(0.073)	(0.072)	(0.025)			
Dep. Var. Mean	-0.146	0.124	0.022	-0.146	0.124	0.022			
# Voters	44,324	44,324	44,324	44,324	44,324	44,324			
# Boundaries	1,029	1,029	1,029	1,029	1,029	1,029			

▸ Placebo sample

Placebo: future boundaries — 2012 Republicans

	Democratic-share treatment			Republican-share treatment			Both treatments		
	ΔRep	ΔUnaff	ΔDem	ΔRep	ΔUnaff	ΔDem	ΔRep	ΔUnaff	ΔDem
$D_{ib}^{\text{Dem}} \times I_b^{\text{Dem}}$	−0.122	0.003	0.119				−0.073	−0.043	0.117
	(0.176)	(0.148)	(0.074)				(0.181)	(0.155)	(0.078)
$D_{ib}^{\text{Rep}} \times I_b^{\text{Rep}}$				−0.112	0.131*	−0.019	−0.130*	0.121	0.009
				(0.073)	(0.072)	(0.025)	(0.076)	(0.075)	(0.026)
Dep. Var. Mean	-0.146	0.124	0.022	-0.146	0.124	0.022	-0.146	0.124	0.022
# Voters	44,324	44,324	44,324	44,324	44,324	44,324	44,324	44,324	44,324
# Boundaries	1,029	1,029	1,029	1,029	1,029	1,029	1,029	1,029	1,029

▸ Placebo sample

Placebo: future boundaries — 2012 Unaffiliated voters

	Democratic-share treatment			Republican-share treatment			Both treatments		
	ΔRep	ΔUnaff	ΔDem	ΔRep	ΔUnaff	ΔDem	ΔRep	ΔUnaff	ΔDem
$D_{ib}^{\text{Dem}} \times I_b^{\text{Dem}}$	0.189	−0.087	−0.102						
	(0.198)	(0.253)	(0.160)						
$D_{ib}^{\text{Rep}} \times I_b^{\text{Rep}}$									
Dep. Var. Mean	0.263	-0.397	0.134						
# Voters	46,835	46,835	46,835						
# Boundaries	1,044	1,044	1,044						

Placebo: future boundaries — 2012 Unaffiliated voters

	Democratic-share treatment			Republican-share treatment			Both treatments		
	ΔRep	ΔUnaff	ΔDem	ΔRep	ΔUnaff	ΔDem	ΔRep	ΔUnaff	ΔDem
$D_{ib}^{\text{Dem}} \times I_b^{\text{Dem}}$	0.189	−0.087	−0.102						
	(0.198)	(0.253)	(0.160)						
$D_{ib}^{\text{Rep}} \times I_b^{\text{Rep}}$				0.022	0.037	−0.059			
				(0.094)	(0.101)	(0.069)			
Dep. Var. Mean	0.263	-0.397	0.134	0.263	-0.397	0.134			
# Voters	46,835	46,835	46,835	46,835	46,835	46,835			
# Boundaries	1,044	1,044	1,044	1,044	1,044	1,044			

Placebo: future boundaries — 2012 Unaffiliated voters

	Democratic-share treatment			Republican-share treatment			Both treatments		
	ΔRep	ΔUnaff	ΔDem	ΔRep	ΔUnaff	ΔDem	ΔRep	ΔUnaff	ΔDem
$D_{ib}^{\text{Dem}} \times I_b^{\text{Dem}}$	0.189	−0.087	−0.102				0.216	−0.074	−0.142
	(0.198)	(0.253)	(0.160)				(0.218)	(0.274)	(0.171)
$D_{ib}^{\text{Rep}} \times I_b^{\text{Rep}}$				0.022	0.037	−0.059	0.035	0.001	−0.037
				(0.094)	(0.101)	(0.069)	(0.105)	(0.107)	(0.073)
Dep. Var. Mean	0.263	-0.397	0.134	0.263	-0.397	0.134	0.263	-0.397	0.134
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# Boundaries	1,044	1,044	1,044	1,044	1,044	1,044	1,044	1,044	1,044

Placebo Test

Same design, using boundaries drawn 2023–2026, after the 2012–2020 outcome window

- Tests whether 2012–2020 partisan trends predict where 2023–2026 new boundaries are drawn
- Smaller and statistically insignificant; largest coefficients opposite to conformity prediction

Robustness

Linearity	Binned dose-response	▸ Figure
Controls	Demographic and property trends; school-zone FEs	▸ Rep. ▸ Unaff.
Bandwidth	50m to 600m around the new line	▸ Figure
Specification	Donut, linear distance, drop largest-gap line, etc.	▸ Figure
Inference	Cluster by boundary pair; Conley SEs at 1–10 km	▸ Table
Randomization inference	1,000 random flips of the high-exposure side	▸ Figure
Attrition	Lee bounds for selective exit from the panel	▸ Table
Mobility	Movers vs. non-movers estimated separately	▸ Rep. ▸ Unaff.

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Mechanisms

A voter assigned to a more Republican ward becomes or stays Republican. Why?

1. **Peer traits:** is it peers' party, or traits correlated with party (race, turnout, age)?
2. **The pulpit:** does the ward's leader drive it?
3. **Friendship:** do the peers most likely to be friends matter most?
4. **Old or new ties:** long-time ward-mates, or newly assigned ones?
5. **Who responds:** which voters switch parties?
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Mechanisms

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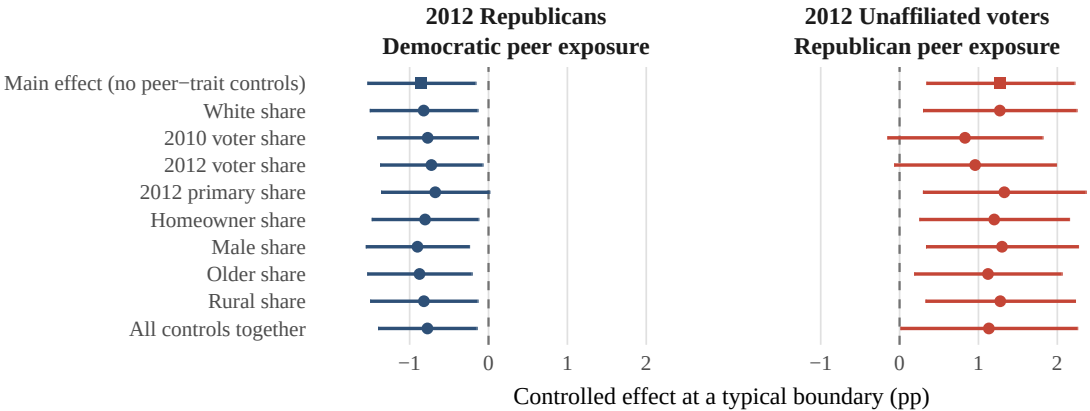
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Peer party or correlated peer traits?

Wards with more Republicans also differ in race, turnout, homeownership, age, and rurality. Is the effect about peers' *party*, or about these traits?

- Add the ward's share of each trait as additional controls
- If party only proxies for a trait, the partisan coefficient shrinks toward zero once that trait is controlled for

Peer party or correlated peer traits?



The partisan effect barely moves with any trait controlled for, one at a time or all together

Mechanisms

A voter assigned to a more Republican ward becomes or stays Republican. Why?

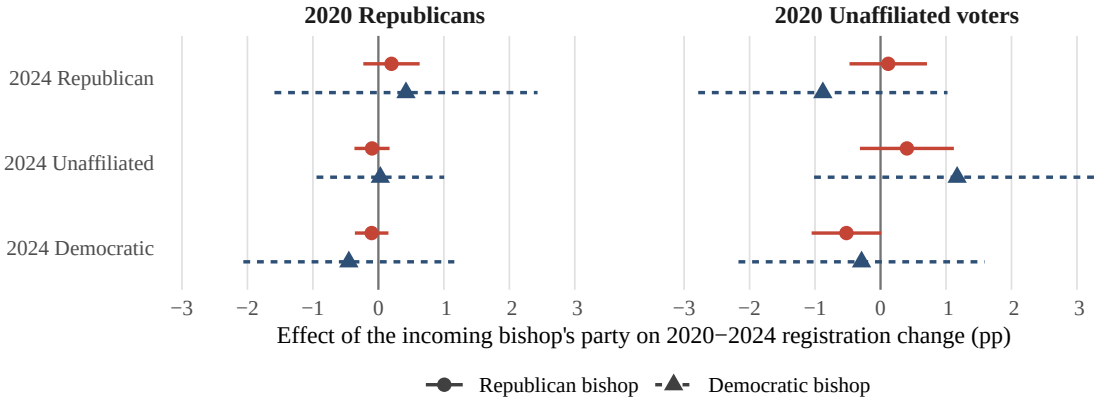
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Is it the pulpit? The bishop's party

- **Bishop**: a ward's lay leader, rotated every five years
- **Data:** newly collected bishop rosters (2023–present), each bishop linked to voter record (L2, 2015–2025), every Utah ward
- **Design:** DiD of members' 2020→2024 registration change on the incoming bishop's party, individual and year FEs
  - 24.9% of wards get a new bishop (spring 2023–2024 election)
  - New bishop's party uncorrelated with old bishop's party
- **Validation:** no effect on the 2016–2020 change, and none from bishops who arrived after the 2024 election

▸ Politics from the pulpit ▸ Pre-trend and placebo

Is it the pulpit? The bishop's party



95% CIs rule out effects above 0.6 pp for Republicans; bishops explain at most 3.1% (Unaffiliated) and 7.9% (Republicans) of the peer effect

▸ Politics from the pulpit ▸ Pre-trend and placebo

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Friendship: same- vs. opposite-gender peers

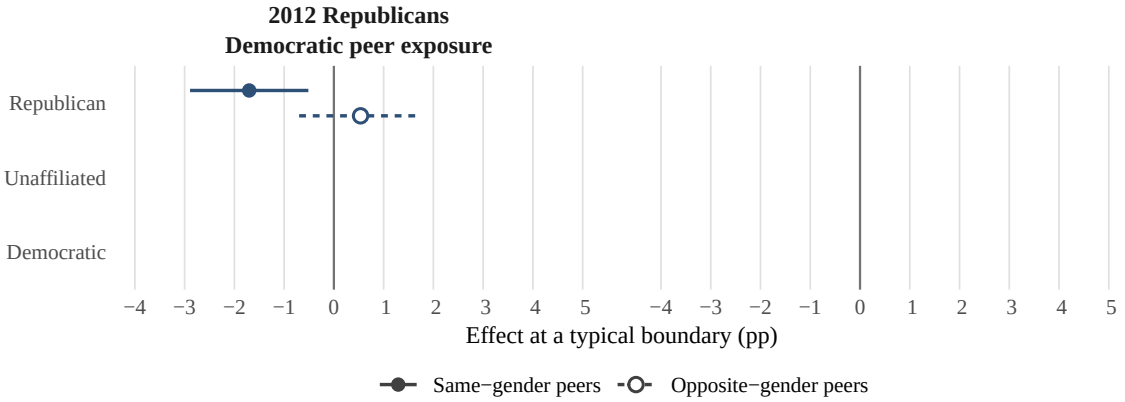
- Friendships form among similar people, and wards organize men and women separately, each with its own home-visiting program
- Split peer exposure into its same-gender and opposite-gender parts and include both:

$$\Delta Y_{ib} = \beta_{\text{same}}\left(D^{s}_{ib} \times |p^{s}_{b} - q^{s}_{b}|\right) + \beta_{\text{opp}}\left(D^{o}_{ib} \times |p^{o}_{b} - q^{o}_{b}|\right) + \dots$$

- A message from the pulpit reaches men and women alike; influence through friendships predicts $\beta_{\text{same}} > \beta_{\text{opp}}$

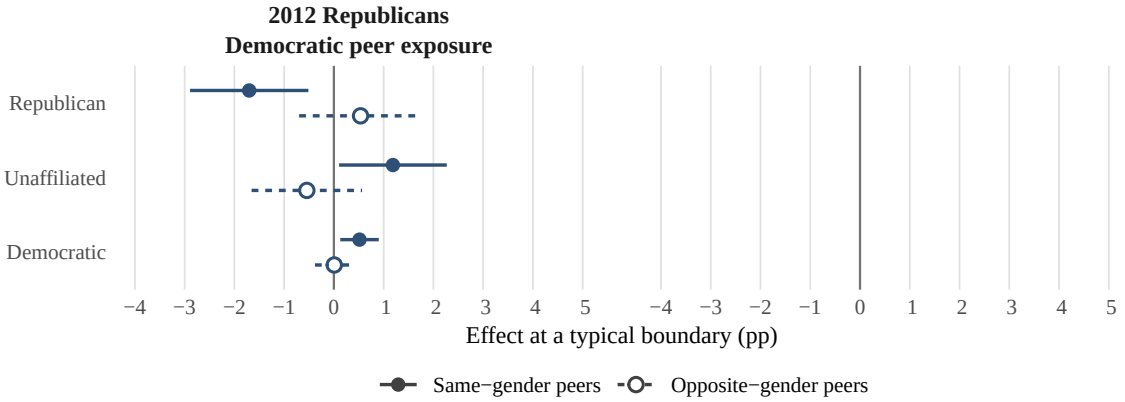
▸ Age, race, homeownership

Friendship: same- vs. opposite-gender peers



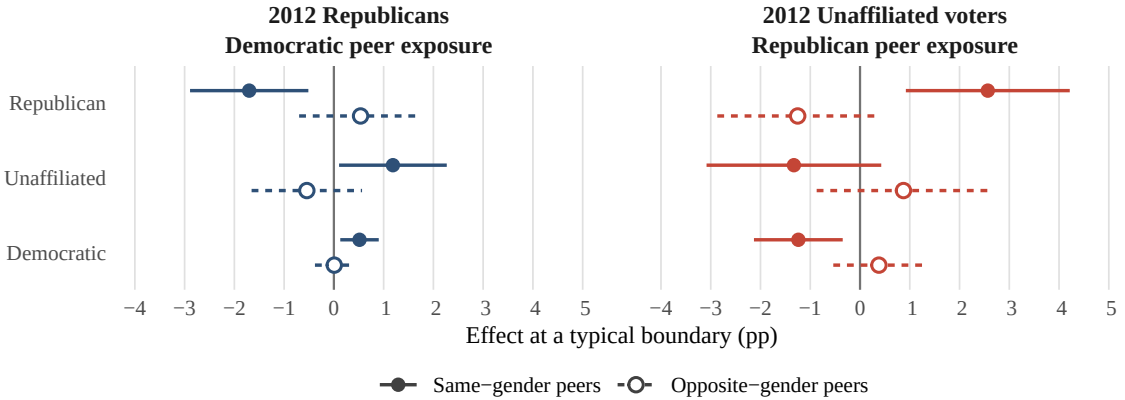
▸ Age, race, homeownership

Friendship: same- vs. opposite-gender peers



▸ Age, race, homeownership

Friendship: same- vs. opposite-gender peers



Same minus opposite: $p = 0.016$ for Unaffiliated → Republican; Republicans' differences point the same way but are weaker

▸ Age, race, homeownership

Mechanisms

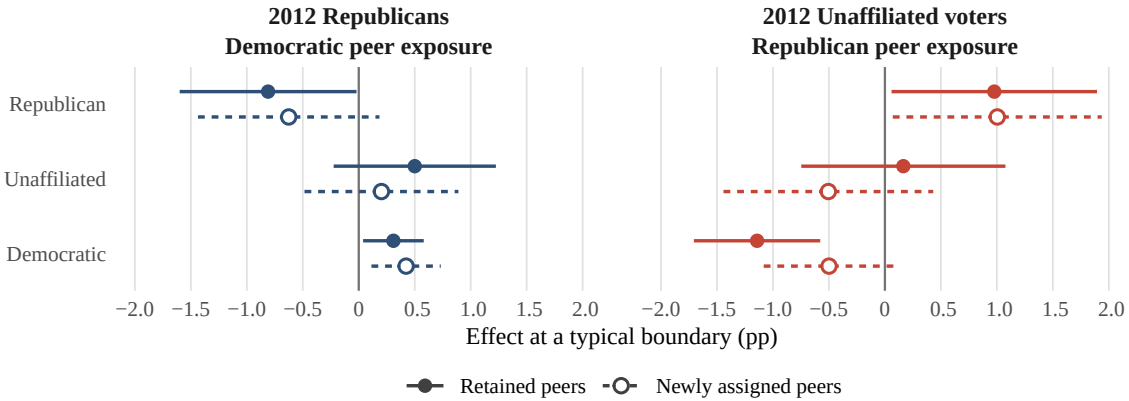
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5. **Who responds:** which voters switch parties?
6. **Strategic registration:** is switching just a way into the closed Republican primary?

Retained vs. newly assigned peers

- A boundary change shifts peer composition *and* breaks up old ties while creating new ones
- Split exposure in the new ward into two parts:
  - **Retained peers:** former ward-mates assigned to the same new ward
  - **Newly assigned peers:** everyone else in the new ward
- Long-standing ties carry accumulated trust; new ties bring views a voter has not yet heard and discounted
- The two parts separate cleanly only where changes were large and newcomers differ, so estimates are less precise

Retained vs. newly assigned peers



Both inherited and newly formed ties transmit partisanship; the two are statistically indistinguishable

Mechanisms

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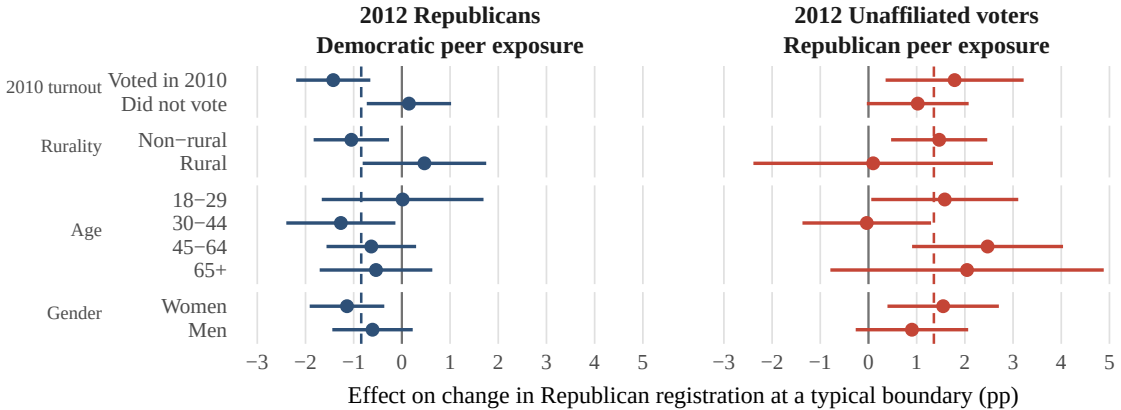
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   → Both, with similar magnitudes
5. **Who responds:** which voters switch parties?
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Which voters respond?

- If persuasion operates through conversation, effects should be stronger for the politically engaged, and those living near fellow members
- Are effects concentrated among young people ← relevant for residential sorting
- Interact the treatment with baseline characteristics
  - prior turnout, rurality, age, gender, race, homeownership, home size, and name commonness

▸ Other characteristics

Which voters respond?



2010 voters respond more than non-voters ($p = 0.005$; survives Bonferroni), non-rural more than rural ($p = 0.040$); no age group stands out

▸ Other characteristics

Mechanisms

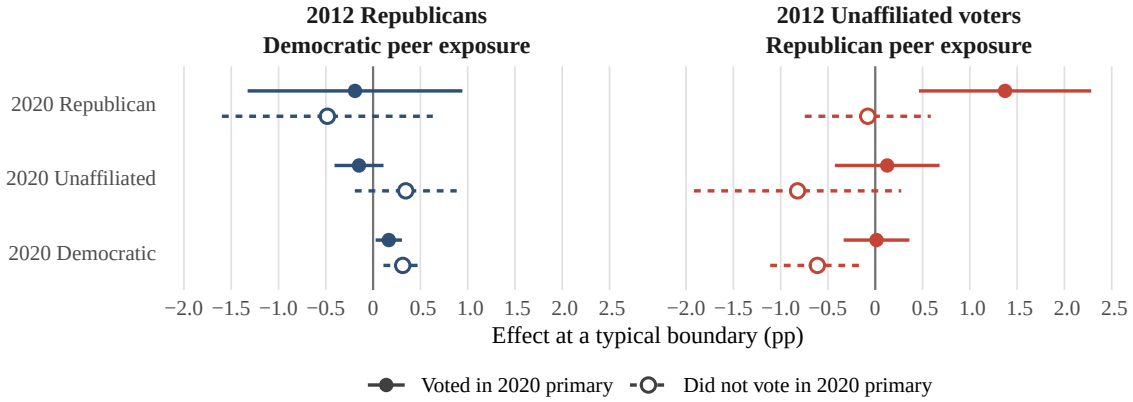
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   → Politically engaged voters, at every age
6. **Strategic registration:** is switching just a way into the closed Republican primary?

Strategic or ideological switching?

- Utah's Republican primary is closed $\Rightarrow$ a strategic reason to register Republican
- 6 outcomes: 2020 party $\times$ primary turnout
  - Switch *and* vote in the new party's primary: consistent with strategic registration
  - Switch *without* voting in it: points to a change in ideology or identity

Strategic or ideological switching?



Unaffiliated → Republican: new Republicans who vote in the primary (strategic, or a two-step)

Republican → Democrat: if anything among non-primary voters ⇒ real ideological change

Mechanisms

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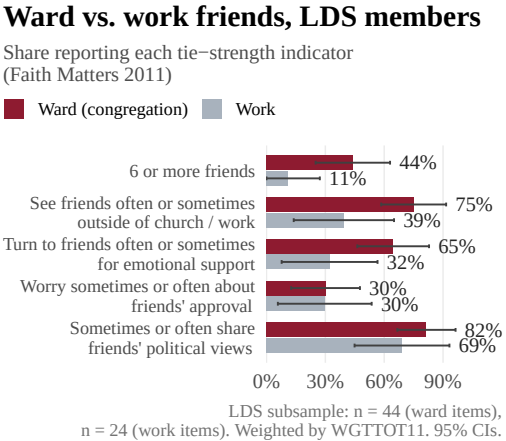
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6. **Strategic registration:** is switching just a way into the closed Republican primary?
   → Not only: Republicans who leave the party mostly skip the primary

Conclusion

- **Finding:** exposure to peers of a party raises the likelihood of adopting that party — congregation assignment causally shifts party registration
- **Magnitude:** a typical boundary moves Republican registration among Unaffiliated voters by 1.4 pp, compared to a base rate of 27.9%
- **Mechanism:** what matters is peers' party, not their other traits or their leaders; effects load on demographically similar peers — influence through close ties, not the shared (and largely apolitical) Sunday experience
- **Implication:** partisanship is transmitted between peers, so partisan sorting compounds itself rather than merely reflecting polarization

Thank you! kgilliat@ucsd.edu

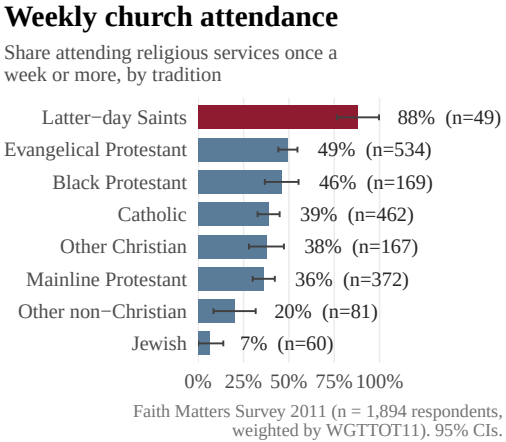
Ward friends are closer than work friends



LDS respondents only, five tie-strength measures. Faith Matters Survey 2011.

Back

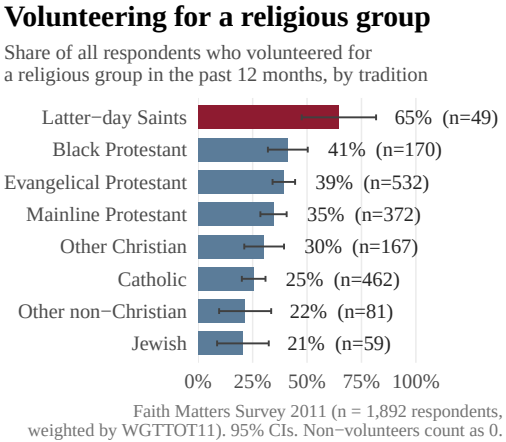
LDS members attend weekly at the highest rate



Share attending religious services once a week or more. Faith Matters Survey 2011.

Back

LDS members volunteer for their congregation at the highest rate



Share who volunteered for a religious group in the past 12 months. Faith Matters Survey 2011.

Back

Survey questions

Emailed to former Utah stake presidents, August 2026; answered in writing or by phone

1. What circumstances typically led to ward boundary adjustments in your stake? When changes were made, what goals were you generally trying to accomplish?
2. When deciding where to draw new boundary lines, how much weight was given to the circumstances of individual households or members, compared with broader factors such as neighborhoods, major roads, school boundaries, or other geographic features?
3. When creating or adjusting wards, did you tend to prioritize similarity within wards or balance across wards? For example, if you were dividing an area containing both a wealthier neighborhood and a lower-income neighborhood into two wards, would you be more likely to (a) draw boundaries so that each ward includes a mix of both neighborhoods, or (b) draw boundaries so that one ward comes mostly from one neighborhood and the other ward mostly from the other?
4. More generally, what principles or considerations most strongly influenced where boundaries were ultimately drawn?

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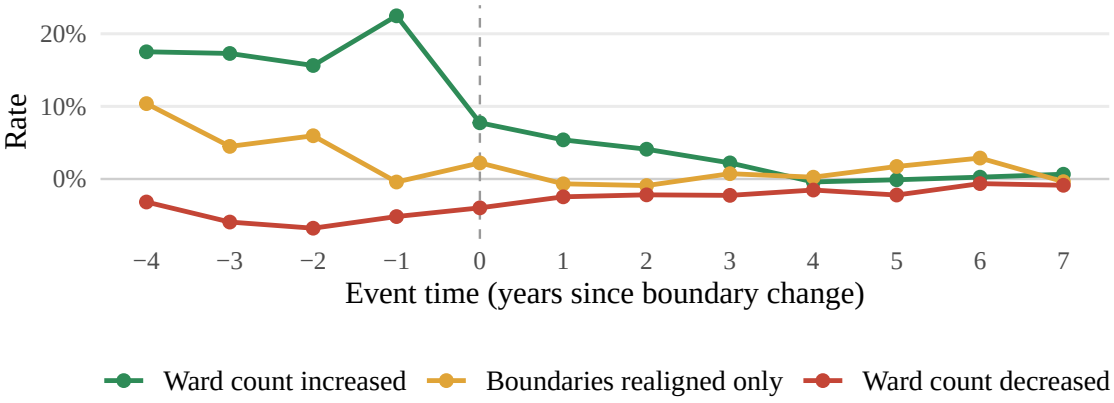
Growth by boundary-change type

	Ward count increased	Boundaries realigned only	Ward count decreased
Wards × Periods (N)	691	640	349
Clusters (N)	196	220	72
Population and growth			
Avg population (2010 imputation)	549	557	792
Avg population (2020 imputation)	1,141	772	905
Population growth, 2010–2020	108.0%	38.5%	14.3%
Voter-file dynamics			
Avg voters (2012)	192	213	315
Avg voters (2020)	393	291	340
Voter-file growth, 2012–2020	95.9%	35.5%	8.0%
Stayed in ward, 2012–2020	37.3%	38.0%	35.8%

Ward-period pairs, 2013–14 through 2016–17; wards defined by their start-of-period boundaries.

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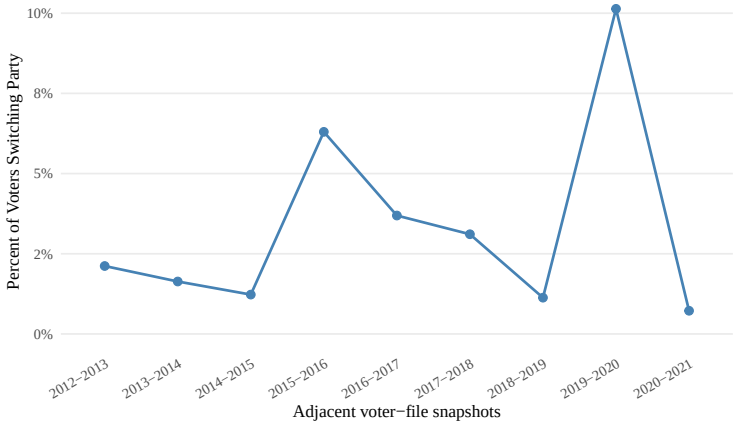
New construction precedes new wards



New-construction rate in event time, pooled 2014–2017 change cohorts, demeaned by calendar year

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Party switching by year



Year-over-year party-switching rates in the cleaned TargetSmart cross sections, 2012–2021.

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Analysis sample by baseline party

	Republicans	Democrats	Unaffiliated
2012 voters near an eligible boundary[a]			
Number of voters	82,307	12,200	75,654
. . . not observed in 2020/2021 (attrition)	26.1%	31.9%	34.3%
Analysis sample[b]			
Number of voters	60,795	8,314	49,684
New boundary lines[a]	1,439	876	1,450
Linked to CoreLogic single-family home	49.3%	40.5%	43.1%
2012 characteristics			
Age	46.3 (16.3)	44.9 (16.1)	42.7 (16.0)
Male	48.8%	44.2%	51.6%
White	97.6%	87.6%	93.6%
Rural	11.2%	5.6%	9.1%
Property value[c]	$274k [215k, 365k]	$247k [195k, 313k]	$253k [201k, 328k]
Year built[c]	1997 [1980, 2004]	1994 [1972, 2002]	1994 [1976, 2003]
Mobility, 2012–2020/21			
Moved[d]	52.2%	57.5%	57.4%
. . . out of Utah[d]	9.5%	15.3%	12.9%
Political outcomes			
Registered Republican in 2020	86.2%	12.6%	29.4%
Registered Democratic in 2020	1.8%	70.6%	10.6%
Registered Unaffiliated in 2020	12.0%	16.8%	59.9%
Voted in 2012 primary	40.1%	4.7%	2.7%
Voted in 2012 general	88.2%	78.8%	73.4%
Voted in 2020 primary[e]	64.2%	26.6%	25.1%
Voted in 2020 general[e]	87.8%	78.2%	78.2%

Voters within 400m of a new 2013–2017 boundary with voters of that party on both sides.

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Sample comparison

	Full 2012 XS	Panel	Analysis	*p*
N	1,091,892	753,451	121,876	—
Political				
Fraction Republican	44.9%	47.4%	50.9%	***
Fraction Democrat	9.1%	9.0%	7.7%	***
Fraction Unaffiliated	46.0%	43.6%	41.4%	***
Voted 2012 general	74.4%	81.6%	81.4%	***
Voted 2012 primary	20.6%	22.4%	21.9%	***
Demographics				
Age	46.9 (18.3)	45.9 (16.7)	44.7 (16.3)	***
Fraction male	49.3%	49.4%	49.6%	*
Fraction white	95.0%	95.5%	95.2%	**
Fraction rural	10.7%	10.8%	9.9%	***
Linked to elementary school	94.9%	94.9%	97.3%	***
Property				
Fraction homeowner	40.4%	44.6%	46.1%	***
Home value (USD)	$262k [203k, 350k]	$267k [206k, 356k]	$263k [208k, 349k]	***
Building size (sq ft)	1,809 [1,373, 2,492]	1,836 [1,394, 2,528]	1,831 [1,408, 2,487]	***
Land size (sq ft)	10,019 [7,841, 13,852]	10,019 [7,841, 13,939]	10,019 [7,841, 13,939]	***
Year built	1986 [1970, 1999]	1987 [1971, 1999]	1996 [1978, 2003]	***
Bedrooms	3 [3, 4]	3 [3, 4]	3 [3, 4]	***
Bathrooms	2.0 [2.0, 3.0]	2.0 [2.0, 3.0]	2.0 [2.0, 3.0]	***
Fraction single-story	76.3%	75.3%	72.3%	***
HMDA income (USD)	$104k [74k, 146k]	$105k [75k, 148k]	$102k [74k, 143k]	*

Full 2012 cross section vs. 2012–2020/21 panel vs. analysis sample.

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Voters linked vs. unlinked to CoreLogic

	Linked to CoreLogic	Not linked	p
N	56,214	65,662	—
Political			
Fraction Republican	54.3%	47.9%	***
Fraction Democrat	6.9%	8.5%	***
Fraction Unaffiliated	38.8%	43.7%	***
Voted 2012 general	88.4%	75.0%	***
Voted 2012 primary	25.1%	19.0%	***
Demographics			
Age	48.1 (14.5)	41.9 (17.1)	***
Fraction male	50.1%	49.2%	**
Fraction white	95.8%	94.7%	***
Fraction rural	7.9%	11.6%	***
Linked to elementary school	98.9%	96.0%	***

2012 registered voters, by whether they link to an owner-occupied single-family CoreLogic record.

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Properties linked vs. unlinked to the voter file

	Linked to voter file	Not linked	p
N	357,240	129,820	—
Demographics			
Fraction rural	9.2%	—	
Property			
Home value (USD)	$257k [197k, 343k]	$215k [168k, 284k]	***
Building size (sq ft)	1,764 [1,340, 2,424]	1,534 [1,180, 2,018]	***
Land size (sq ft)	9,583 [7,405, 13,504]	8,276 [5,663, 11,326]	***
Year built	1987 [1969, 2000]	1985 [1964, 2001]	***
Bedrooms	3 [3, 4]	3 [3, 4]	***
Bathrooms	2.0 [2.0, 3.0]	2.0 [2.0, 3.0]	***
Fraction single-story	76.0%	75.9%	
HMDA income (USD)	$98k [68k, 141k]	$77k [53k, 113k]	***

2012 owner-occupied single-family CoreLogic properties, by whether they link to a registered voter.

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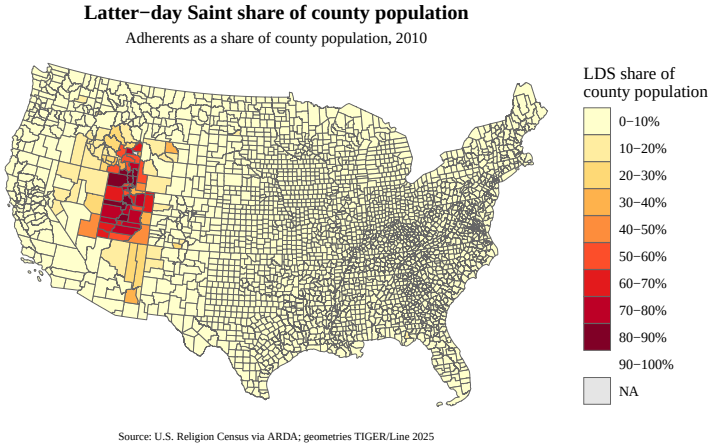
Main vs. placebo sample

	Main analysis	Placebo analysis	*p*
N	121,876	103,335	—
Political			
Fraction Republican	50.9%	43.8%	***
Fraction Democrat	7.7%	10.3%	***
Fraction Unaffiliated	41.4%	46.0%	***
Voted 2012 general	81.4%	80.8%	***
Voted 2012 primary	21.9%	21.1%	***
Demographics			
Age	44.7 (16.3)	45.5 (16.7)	***
Fraction male	49.6%	49.3%	
Fraction white	95.2%	94.2%	***
Fraction rural	9.9%	5.4%	***
Linked to elementary school	97.3%	98.4%	***
Property			
Fraction homeowner	46.1%	44.6%	***
Home value (USD)	$263k [208k, 349k]	$244k [191k, 314k]	***
Building size (sq ft)	1,831 [1,408, 2,487]	1,716 [1,302, 2,330]	***
Land size (sq ft)	10,019 [7,841, 13,939]	9,148 [7,405, 11,761]	***
Year built	1996 [1978, 2003]	1983 [1966, 1998]	***
Bedrooms	3 [3, 4]	3 [3, 4]	***
Bathrooms	2.0 [2.0, 3.0]	2.0 [2.0, 3.0]	***
Fraction single-story	72.3%	77.7%	***
HMDA income (USD)	$102k [74k, 143k]	$96k [68k, 132k]	***

Placebo sample: voters within 400m of boundaries drawn 2023–2026, after the outcome window.

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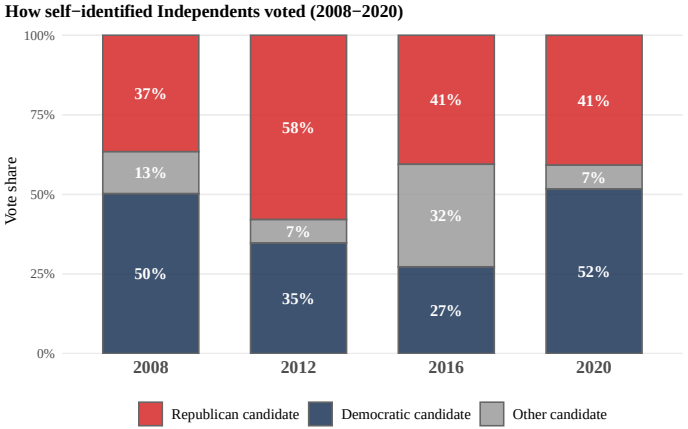
LDS adherents by county, 2010



LDS adherents as a share of county population, 2010 U.S. Religion Census.

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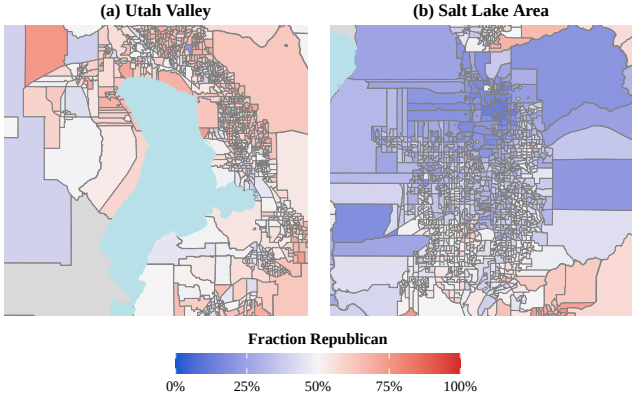
Presidential vote of Utah Independents



Self-identified Independents and leaners (CES `pid7` 3–5), among respondents reporting a vote.

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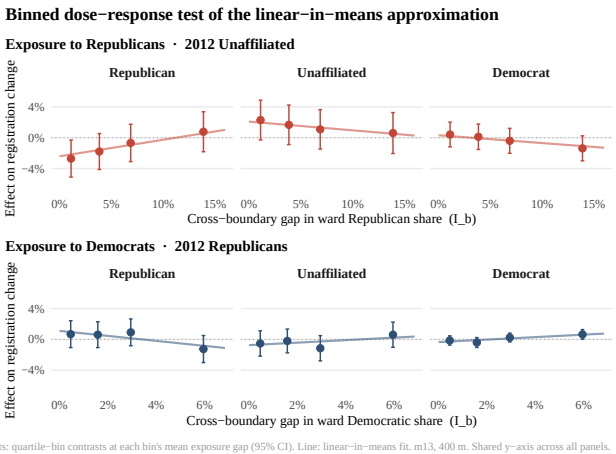
Ward-level Republican share, 2012



Share of 2012 registered voters who are Republican, 2013 ward boundaries.

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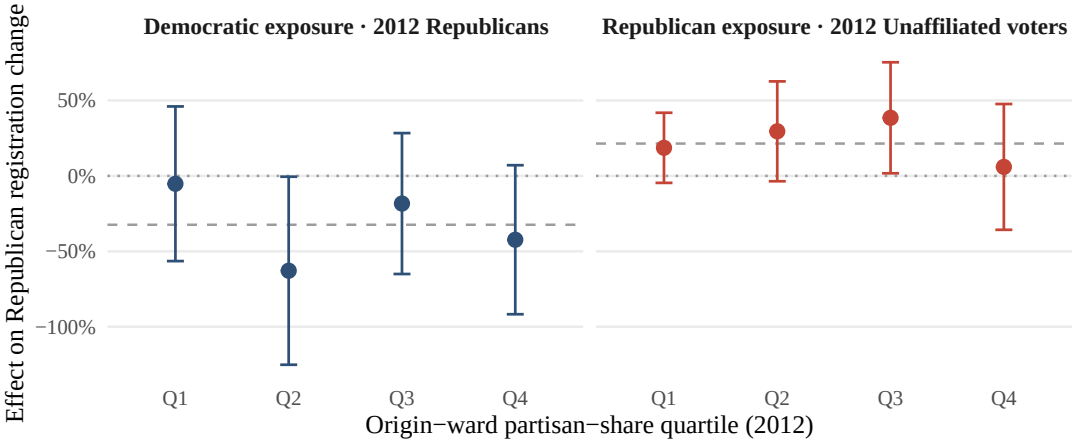
Linearity: binned dose-response



Quartile-bin contrasts of the exposure gap at each bin's mean gap, with the linear fit.

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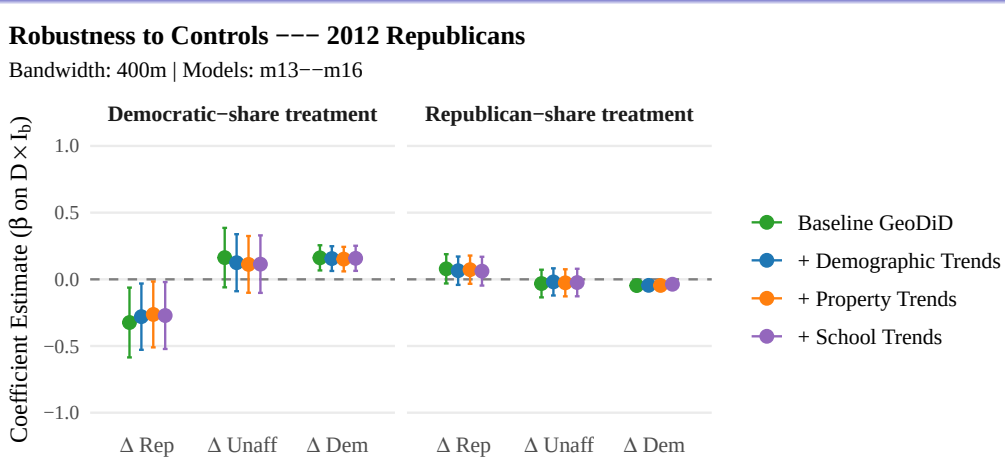
Linearity: effects by origin-ward composition



Treatment effects by quartile of the origin ward's 2012 partisan share. Dashed line: pooled estimate.

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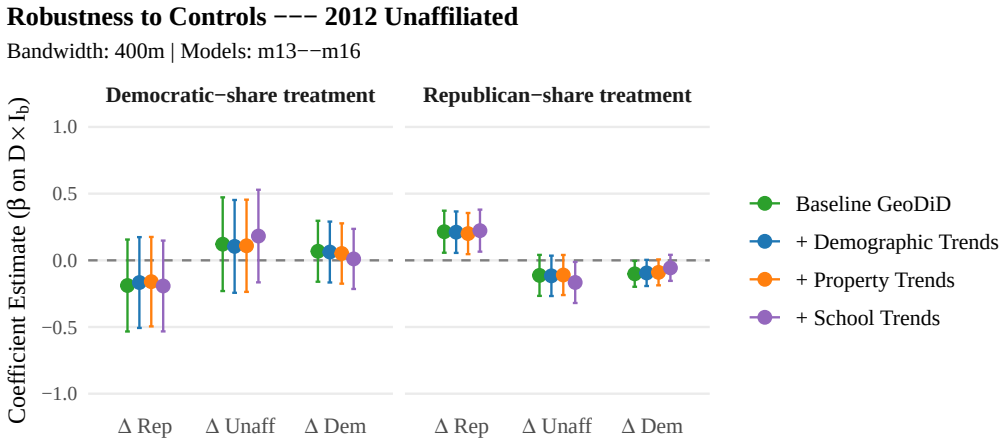
Robustness to controls — 2012 Republicans



Preferred specification, then adding demographic trends, property trends, and school-catchment fixed effects.

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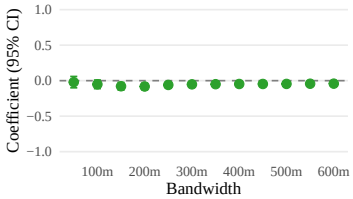
Robustness to controls — 2012 Unaffiliated voters



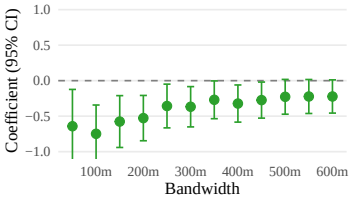
Preferred specification, then adding demographic trends, property trends, and school-catchment fixed effects.

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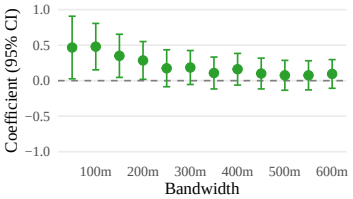
Robustness to bandwidth



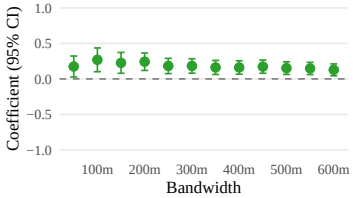
Rep. → Dem. (Rep. exposure)



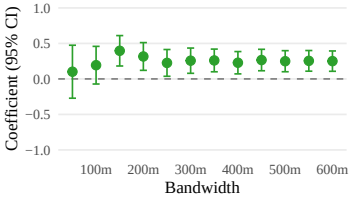
Rep. → Rep. (Dem. exposure)



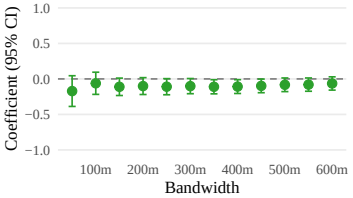
Rep. → Unaff. (Dem. exposure)



Rep. → Dem. (Dem. exposure)



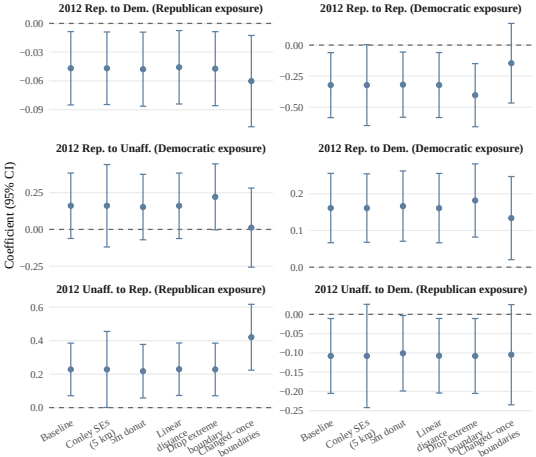
Unaff. → Rep. (Rep. exposure)



Unaff. → Dem. (Rep. exposure)

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Alternative specifications



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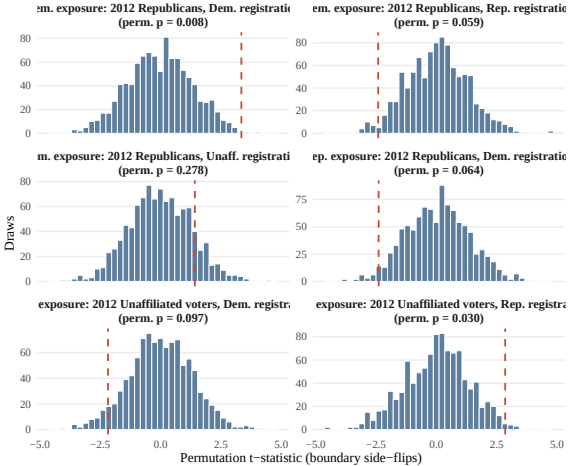
Alternative inference

	$\hat{\beta}$ (SE)	*p*-value under alternative inference						
		Two-way cluster	Cluster by boundary	Conley 1 km	Conley 2 km	Conley 5 km	Conley 10 km	Randomization
2012 Unaff. → 2020 Rep. (Rep. exposure)	0.228*** (0.080)	0.004	0.023	0.034	0.044	0.049	0.087	0.030
2012 Unaff. → 2020 Dem. (Rep. exposure)	−0.108** (0.050)	0.029	0.078	0.131	0.121	0.114	0.168	0.097
2012 Rep. → 2020 Rep. (Dem. exposure)	−0.322** (0.133)	0.016	0.045	0.055	0.074	0.053	0.028	0.059
2012 Rep. → 2020 Dem. (Dem. exposure)	0.161*** (0.048)	0.001	0.006	0.003	0.002	0.001	0.001	0.008
2012 Rep. → 2020 Unaff. (Dem. exposure)	0.161 (0.114)	0.157	0.239	0.274	0.310	0.260	0.183	0.278
2012 Rep. → 2020 Dem. (Rep. exposure)	−0.047** (0.020)	0.017	0.056	0.041	0.044	0.015	0.009	0.064

p-values for the six main estimates under each method. Randomization: 1,000 side-flip draws.

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Randomization inference



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Attrition: Lee bounds

	Point	Lower bound	Upper bound	Ret. diff.	Trim share
2012 Rep. → 2020 Rep. (Rep. exposure)	0.079	0.074	0.103	−0.005	0.043
	(0.057)	(0.060)	(0.064)		
2012 Rep. → 2020 Unaff. (Rep. exposure)	−0.033	−0.052	−0.025		
	(0.053)	(0.059)	(0.057)		
2012 Rep. → 2020 Dem. (Rep. exposure)	−0.047**	−0.049**	−0.047**		
	(0.020)	(0.020)	(0.019)		
2012 Rep. → 2020 Rep. (Dem. exposure)	−0.322**	−0.330**	−0.279**	−0.005	0.051
	(0.133)	(0.141)	(0.135)		
2012 Rep. → 2020 Unaff. (Dem. exposure)	0.161	0.122	0.158		
	(0.114)	(0.114)	(0.119)		
2012 Rep. → 2020 Dem. (Dem. exposure)	0.161***	0.129***	0.171***		
	(0.048)	(0.045)	(0.051)		
2012 Unaff. → 2020 Rep. (Rep. exposure)	0.228***	0.166*	0.329***	+0.001	0.057
	(0.080)	(0.100)	(0.082)		
2012 Unaff. → 2020 Unaff. (Rep. exposure)	−0.120	−0.217**	−0.044		
	(0.079)	(0.085)	(0.097)		
2012 Unaff. → 2020 Dem. (Rep. exposure)	−0.108**	−0.112**	−0.108**		
	(0.050)	(0.054)	(0.050)		
2012 Unaff. → 2020 Rep. (Dem. exposure)	−0.182	−0.253	−0.094	−0.003	0.052
	(0.176)	(0.188)	(0.198)		
2012 Unaff. → 2020 Unaff. (Dem. exposure)	0.117	−0.021	0.202		
	(0.179)	(0.205)	(0.196)		
2012 Unaff. → 2020 Dem. (Dem. exposure)	0.064	0.053	0.154		
	(0.117)	(0.123)	(0.125)		

Trimmed within boundary on the higher-retention side. Ret. diff.: high- minus low-exposure side.

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Movers vs. non-movers — 2012 Republicans

	Democratic-share treatment			Republican-share treatment			Both treatments		
	ΔRep	ΔUnaff	ΔDem	ΔRep	ΔUnaff	ΔDem	ΔRep	ΔUnaff	ΔDem
Panel A: Non-movers									
$D_{ib}^{\text{Dem}} \times I_b^{\text{Dem}}$	−0.206*	0.100	0.106*				−0.167	0.062	0.105*
	(0.115)	(0.100)	(0.056)				(0.117)	(0.101)	(0.058)
$D_{ib}^{\text{Rep}} \times I_b^{\text{Rep}}$				0.080	−0.040	−0.041*	0.060	−0.033	−0.027
				(0.052)	(0.047)	(0.021)	(0.053)	(0.048)	(0.022)
Joint test *p*-value		0.099			0.111			0.217	
p-value: $\beta_{\text{Dem}} = -\beta_{\text{Rep}}$							0.423	0.806	0.211
Dep. Var. Mean	-0.051	0.042	0.010	-0.051	0.042	0.010	-0.051	0.042	0.010
# Voters	28,975	28,975	28,975	28,975	28,975	28,975	28,975	28,975	28,975
# Boundaries	1,373	1,373	1,373	1,373	1,373	1,373	1,373	1,373	1,373
Panel B: Movers									
$D_{ib}^{\text{Dem}} \times I_b^{\text{Dem}}$	−0.243	0.053	0.190**				−0.200	0.029	0.171**
	(0.189)	(0.177)	(0.078)				(0.203)	(0.187)	(0.082)
$D_{ib}^{\text{Rep}} \times I_b^{\text{Rep}}$				0.110	−0.058	−0.052*	0.076	−0.040	−0.037
				(0.085)	(0.085)	(0.031)	(0.089)	(0.088)	(0.031)
Joint test *p*-value		0.045			0.156			0.128	
p-value: $\beta_{\text{Dem}} = -\beta_{\text{Rep}}$							0.613	0.964	0.134
Dep. Var. Mean	-0.219	0.194	0.025	-0.219	0.194	0.025	-0.219	0.194	0.025
# Voters	31,646	31,646	31,646	31,646	31,646	31,646	31,646	31,646	31,646
# Boundaries	1,416	1,416	1,416	1,416	1,416	1,416	1,416	1,416	1,416
Panel C: Movers minus non-movers									
$\beta_{\text{Dem}}^{\text{M}} - \beta_{\text{Dem}}^{\text{N}}$	−0.037	−0.046	0.084				−0.034	−0.033	0.066
	(0.211)	(0.205)	(0.096)				(0.227)	(0.216)	(0.099)
p-value: Dem. equality	0.860	0.821	0.382				0.882	0.880	0.503
$\beta_{\text{Rep}}^{\text{M}} - \beta_{\text{Rep}}^{\text{N}}$				0.030	−0.019	−0.011	0.016	−0.007	−0.009
				(0.099)	(0.097)	(0.039)	(0.104)	(0.100)	(0.038)
p-value: Rep. equality				0.763	0.847	0.769	0.879	0.948	0.810
Joint equality *p*-value		0.680			0.932			0.971	
Boundary FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Distance Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

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Movers vs. non-movers — 2012 Unaffiliated voters

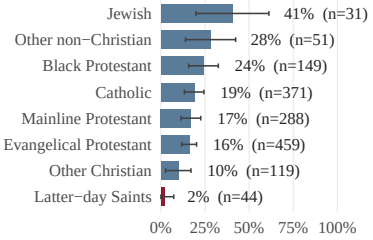
	Democratic-share treatment			Republican-share treatment			Both treatments		
	ΔRep	ΔUnaff	ΔDem	ΔRep	ΔUnaff	ΔDem	ΔRep	ΔUnaff	ΔDem
Panel A: Non-movers									
$D_{ib}^{\text{Dem}} \times I_b^{\text{Dem}}$	−0.255	0.069	0.186				−0.110	−0.111	0.221
	(0.302)	(0.313)	(0.181)				(0.305)	(0.327)	(0.183)
$D_{ib}^{\text{Rep}} \times I_b^{\text{Rep}}$				0.396***	−0.331**	−0.065	0.347**	−0.353**	0.006
				(0.137)	(0.135)	(0.088)	(0.141)	(0.143)	(0.088)
Joint test *p*-value		0.489			0.014			0.079	
p-value: $\beta_{\text{Dem}} = -\beta_{\text{Rep}}$							0.511	0.231	0.284
Dep. Var. Mean	0.293	-0.389	0.096	0.293	-0.389	0.096	0.293	-0.389	0.096
# Voters	21,096	21,096	21,096	21,096	21,096	21,096	21,096	21,096	21,096
# Boundaries	1,335	1,335	1,335	1,335	1,335	1,335	1,335	1,335	1,335
Panel B: Movers									
$D_{ib}^{\text{Dem}} \times I_b^{\text{Dem}}$	−0.334	0.242	0.092				−0.257	0.329	−0.072
	(0.228)	(0.233)	(0.166)				(0.245)	(0.257)	(0.173)
$D_{ib}^{\text{Rep}} \times I_b^{\text{Rep}}$				0.176*	−0.043	−0.134**	0.135	0.004	−0.139*
				(0.105)	(0.104)	(0.067)	(0.112)	(0.115)	(0.071)
Joint test *p*-value		0.340			0.076			0.164	
p-value: $\beta_{\text{Dem}} = -\beta_{\text{Rep}}$							0.687	0.297	0.304
Dep. Var. Mean	0.297	-0.410	0.113	0.297	-0.410	0.113	0.297	-0.410	0.113
# Voters	28,455	28,455	28,455	28,455	28,455	28,455	28,455	28,455	28,455
# Boundaries	1,409	1,409	1,409	1,409	1,409	1,409	1,409	1,409	1,409
Panel C: Movers minus non-movers									
$\beta_{\text{Dem}}^{\text{M}} - \beta_{\text{Dem}}^{\text{N}}$	−0.079	0.173	−0.094				−0.147	0.439	−0.292
	(0.371)	(0.389)	(0.249)				(0.384)	(0.413)	(0.250)
p-value: Dem. equality	0.831	0.657	0.706				0.701	0.287	0.242
$\beta_{\text{Rep}}^{\text{M}} - \beta_{\text{Rep}}^{\text{N}}$				−0.220	0.289*	−0.069	−0.212	0.358*	−0.146
				(0.166)	(0.168)	(0.114)	(0.176)	(0.183)	(0.115)
p-value: Rep. equality				0.186	0.087	0.546	0.228	0.051	0.205
Joint equality *p*-value		0.884			0.230			0.283	
Boundary FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Distance Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

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LDS pulpits are rarely political

Political issues from the pulpit

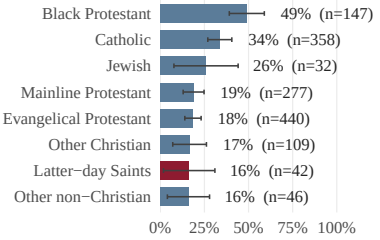
Share of attenders reporting political issues are discussed at least monthly, by tradition



Faith Matters Survey 2011 (n = 1,512 attenders, weighted by WGTTOT11). 95% CIs.

Congregation voter mobilization

Share of attenders whose congregation organizes voter registration or distributes voter guides



Faith Matters Survey 2011 (n = 1,451 attenders, weighted by WGTTOT11). 95% CIs.

Faith Matters Survey 2011, attenders by religious tradition.

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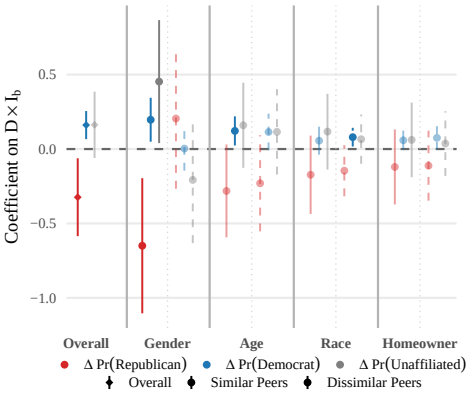
Bishop party: pre-trend and placebo (2020 Republicans)

	Republican bishop			Democratic bishop		
	ΔRep	ΔDem	ΔUnaff	ΔRep	ΔDem	ΔUnaff
Bishop party (2020 → 2024)	0.002	−0.001	−0.001	0.004	−0.005	0.000
	(0.002)	(0.001)	(0.001)	(0.010)	(0.008)	(0.005)
Pre-trend (2016 → 2020)	0.001	−0.001	0.000	0.009	−0.006*	−0.004
	(0.002)	(0.001)	(0.002)	(0.006)	(0.003)	(0.005)
Placebo (post-election change)	−0.003	0.001	0.002	0.006	0.000	−0.007
	(0.002)	(0.001)	(0.002)	(0.005)	(0.002)	(0.005)
Individual FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Dep. Var. Mean	0.969	0.005	0.026	0.969	0.005	0.026
# Voters	515,828	515,828	515,828	515,828	515,828	515,828
# Wards	3,364	3,364	3,364	3,364	3,364	3,364

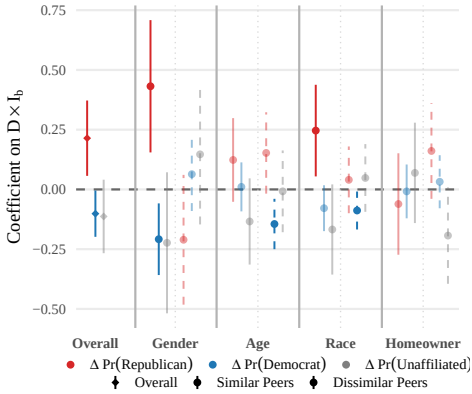
Row 2: the 2023–24 bishop change applied to the 2016–2020 registration change. Row 3: bishop changes after the 2024 election. Standard errors clustered by ward.

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Same- vs. opposite-demographic peers



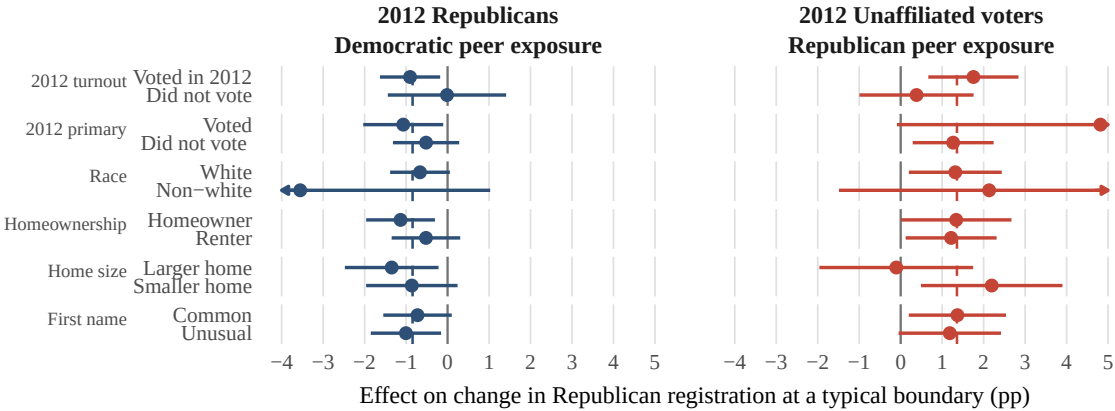
Democratic exposure, 2012 Republicans



Republican exposure, 2012 Unaffiliated voters

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Which voters respond: other characteristics



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